Archiving Chhath Puja Folk Songs: A Digital Ethnographic Study

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Abstract

Chhath Puja is a major ritual festival of eastern India, particularly in the Purvanchal region of Bihar, where folk songs play a central role in religious practice and community life. These songs are transmitted orally and performed during specific stages of the ritual, making them living traditions that depend on collective memory and participation. In recent decades, large scale migration and changing social conditions have disrupted traditional modes of transmission. As younger generations move away from their native regions, opportunities for learning and performing Chhath songs through embodied ritual practice have declined. This situation raises urgent questions about how such oral traditions can be documented and sustained without separating them from their cultural context.

This paper presents a website based digital archiving project focused on Chhath Puja folk songs from Bihar. Using a digital ethnographic framework, the study combines oral history interviews, audio and video documentation, and archival research to record both performances and the narratives surrounding them. Fifteen qualitative interviews with singers, ritual participants, and community elders were conducted to trace personal memories, migration experiences, and changes in song transmission. These contemporary accounts were contextualized through district gazetteers and archival sources from Muzaffarpur to situate present practices within a longer historical framework. The digital archive consists of two core elements, a song archive organized according to ritual stages and a historical map that links songs and narratives to place based memory.

The project follows community based archiving principles, emphasizing informed consent, collaborative representation, and ethical responsibility. Through critical discussion, the paper argues that digital archiving can function as a safeguarding practice when it supports continuity without claiming to replace living traditions. While digital platforms create new memory spaces and increase access for migrant communities, they also transform how traditions are experienced and remembered. By acknowledging these tensions, the study contributes to debates in Digital Humanities, folkloristics, and ethnomusicology, demonstrating how small scale, community oriented digital archives can ethically support the preservation of living oral traditions in the digital age.

Keywords: Chhath Puja, Digital Archiving, Oral Tradition, Cultural Memory, Digital Ethnography

Introduction

Chhath Puja is one of the most important ritual festivals of eastern India, especially in the Purvanchal region of Bihar. The festival is dedicated to the worship of the Sun and is observed through a sequence of collective rituals performed near rivers, ponds, and other water bodies. Alongside fasting and ritual offerings, folk songs play a central role in Chhath Puja. These songs are sung during different stages of the ritual and are closely tied to prayer, memory, and community life. They are not performed for entertainment alone but function as a medium through which religious devotion, social values, and collective emotions are expressed. Chhath folk songs therefore exist as living oral traditions that are transmitted through performance rather than through written texts.

Traditionally, these songs have been passed down orally across generations, often within families or local communities. Women play a particularly important role in preserving and transmitting Chhath songs, as they are often the primary performers during ritual gatherings. The songs carry references to local landscapes, kinship relations, agricultural cycles, and mythological narratives. Because of their oral nature, Chhath songs remain flexible and adaptive. Lyrics may change slightly across regions or families, and melodies often vary depending on the singer and context. This fluidity is a defining feature of oral traditions and allows them to remain relevant within changing social environments.

Despite their cultural significance, Chhath folk songs face increasing challenges in the present day. Large scale migration from Bihar to urban centers and other states has disrupted the everyday contexts in which these songs were traditionally learned and performed. Younger generations who grow up away from their native villages often have limited exposure to ritual performances. Even when Chhath Puja is observed in migrant communities, the songs are frequently replaced by recorded music circulated through loudspeakers or online platforms. While these recordings help keep the sound of Chhath alive, they often detach songs from their local performers, ritual meanings, and social contexts. As a result, the intergenerational transmission of oral knowledge weakens, and the role of community memory becomes fragmented.

Recent public and policy discourse has increasingly framed Chhath Puja within the language of cultural heritage, including discussions around its possible recognition as intangible cultural heritage. Such recognition reflects both acknowledgment of the festival's significance and concern about the vulnerability of its oral and performative dimensions. However, heritage recognition also raises questions about how living traditions can be preserved without being reduced to static symbols. Digital documentation thus emerges as a necessary but complex intervention.

This paper responds to these concerns by presenting a community based digital archiving project focused on Chhath Puja folk songs from Purvanchal, Bihar. Using digital ethnography, oral history, and archival research, the project documents songs as situated cultural practices rather than isolated musical objects. The study examines how a community based digital archive can ethically safeguard Chhath Puja's oral traditions.

Conceptual Framework and Literature Review

This study draws on folklore studies, ethnomusicology, cultural theory, and Digital Humanities to understand Chhath Puja folk songs as living oral and ritual traditions and to frame digital archiving as an ethical cultural practice. Rather than treating folk songs as static cultural texts, this framework approaches them as performative practices shaped by ritual, memory, gender, migration, and social change.

Oral traditions depend on spoken transmission and repeated performance rather than written documentation. Folklore scholars emphasize that such traditions are recreated each time they are performed and remain open to variation across regions and generations

(Finnegan 5). Chhath Puja folk songs function within this oral framework. They are learned through participation in ritual gatherings and gain meaning through repetition, collective singing, and embodied practice. This performative nature allows flexibility, but it also makes oral traditions vulnerable when transmission networks weaken.

Ritual performance is central to the cultural meaning of Chhath songs. Rituals actively produce social bonds and shared values rather than merely expressing belief (Turner 44). Chhath songs accompany specific ritual stages and help structure the temporal and emotional rhythm of the festival. Deepshikha's ecofeminist study of Chhath Puja further highlights the gendered and ecological dimensions of these practices, showing how women's ritual labor and engagement with natural elements such as water and the sun are central to the festival's cultural meaning (Deepshikha). This perspective reinforces the argument that Chhath songs cannot be separated from embodied ritual practice, gendered participation, and environmental context.

Migration has significantly altered the conditions of oral transmission. Cultural memory scholars note that migration and urbanization disrupt intergenerational interaction, weakening everyday practices of oral learning (Assmann 38). Ethnomusicological research shows that folk songs often function as carriers of emotional and social memory in migrant contexts (Stokes 4). Bhojpuri folk genres such as Bidesiya songs articulate themes of separation, longing, and mobility, revealing how music operates as affective memory within migrant cultures (Gupta and Gupta 62). Contemporary digital initiatives such as *The Bidesia Project* demonstrate how migrant narratives and vernacular expression can be documented through participatory digital storytelling, offering an important methodological precedent for community oriented digital archiving (Bhagat Studios).

Chhath Puja songs similarly help recreate a sense of belonging for migrant communities, even as modes of performance change. Alongside cultural impacts, scholars have also examined the social dimensions of the festival. Pandey, Singh, and Kumar's study of Chhath Puja and health seeking behavior highlights how ritual practice intersects with public health, community discipline, and embodied risk, further emphasizing the deeply lived and social nature of the festival (Pandey et al.). Such studies underline the importance of documenting Chhath Puja as a complex social practice rather than a symbolic tradition alone.

Digital Humanities scholarship provides tools for responding to these changes. Digital ethnography allows researchers to study cultural practices across online and offline spaces as interconnected environments (Pink et al. 3). Digital oral history enables the preservation of voice, narrative, and performance, while raising ethical concerns around consent and representation (Shopes 20). Community based archiving frameworks address these concerns by emphasizing collaboration and shared authority, allowing communities to retain control over how their cultural practices are represented (Caswell 6). Within UNESCO's framework of intangible cultural heritage, such community participation is central to safeguarding living traditions rather than freezing them into static forms (UNESCO 2).

By bringing together oral tradition theory, migration and memory studies, gender and ecological perspectives, and participatory digital practice, this framework positions digital archiving as a cultural intervention rather than a neutral technical process. It provides the theoretical grounding for understanding how a community based digital archive can ethically support the continuity of Chhath Puja's living oral traditions in the digital present.

Methodology: Digital Ethnography and Archival Practice

This study follows a qualitative research design grounded in digital ethnography, oral history, and archival research to document Chhath Puja folk songs as living oral and ritual traditions. The methodology was shaped by the need to capture performance, memory, and historical context together, while remaining attentive to ethical and community concerns.

Digital ethnography provided the primary research framework. Cultural practices related to Chhath Puja today operate across both physical and digital spaces, including ritual gatherings, mobile devices, and online media. The study therefore examined songs as they are performed, remembered, and circulated in both offline and online environments (Pink et al. 3). This approach allowed the research to account for the role of digital media in sustaining cultural practices among migrant communities.

Oral history interviews were central to the research process. Fifteen qualitative interviews were conducted with singers, ritual participants, and community elders from the Purvanchal region of Bihar. Due to geographic dispersion, several interviews and recordings were conducted through digital platforms. The interviews focused on personal experiences of learning and performing Chhath songs, memories of ritual practice, and the impact of migration and generational change. Oral history was used to foreground lived experience and subjective memory in a context where written documentation of folk practices is limited (Shopes 20).

Archival research was used to contextualize these contemporary narratives. District gazetteers of Muzaffarpur from the colonial and postcolonial periods were consulted to trace historical references to local festivals, ritual practices, and social organization. These archival sources were used to triangulate interview narratives rather than to establish authoritative accounts, allowing the study to place present practices within a longer historical frame.

Audio and video documentation was used to record songs and associated narratives. Recordings were accompanied by contextual metadata such as ritual stage, language, location, and performer background. All participants were informed about the purpose of the project and the public nature of the digital archive, and consent was obtained prior to recording. Contributors were given control over how their recordings would be represented, aligning the project with community based archiving principles (Caswell 6).

The digital archive was designed as a website with two core elements, a song archive and a historical map. Songs are organized according to ritual stages, and the map links performances and narratives to place based memory. Through this integrated methodology,

the study positions digital archiving as a culturally sensitive practice that supports continuity while respecting the living and evolving nature of oral tradition.

The Digital Archive: Design, Interface, and Content

The digital archive developed for this study is intentionally minimal and focused. It consists of two core elements, a song archive and a historical map. This design choice reflects a methodological commitment to clarity, accessibility, and cultural context rather than technological complexity. By limiting the number of features, the archive foregrounds oral tradition, ritual sequencing, and spatial memory as its primary interpretive frames.

The song archive forms the central component of the website. It contains audio and video recordings of Chhath Puja folk songs collected through digital ethnography and oral history interviews. Songs are organized according to ritual stages of Chhath Puja, allowing users to encounter them in a sequence that mirrors live ritual practice. This structure resists the common tendency of digital music platforms to categorize folk songs by genre or popularity, instead emphasizing ritual function and cultural meaning.

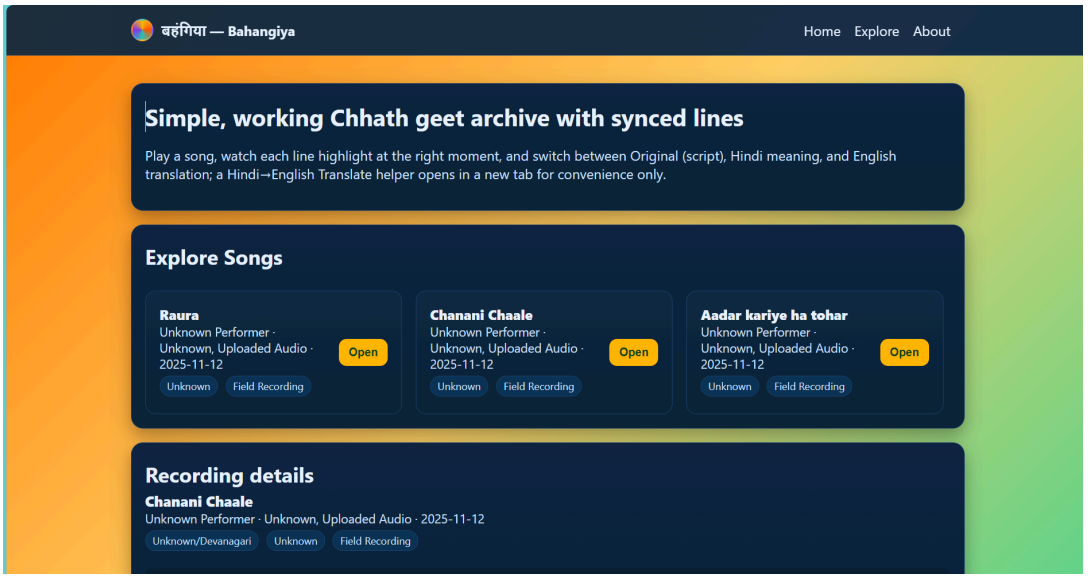

Fig. 1. The homepage of the website with the song archive as the main entry point.

Each song entry includes the recording along with brief contextual information such as ritual stage, language, place of recording, and performer details when consent was provided. Short descriptions explain how and when the song is traditionally performed and what it signifies within the ritual. These descriptions are drawn from interview narratives and field observations, ensuring that songs are presented as situated practices rather than decontextualized audio files. The archive includes performances in Bhojpuri, Maithili, and regional Hindi varieties, with concise explanations in English to maintain accessibility without erasing linguistic specificity.

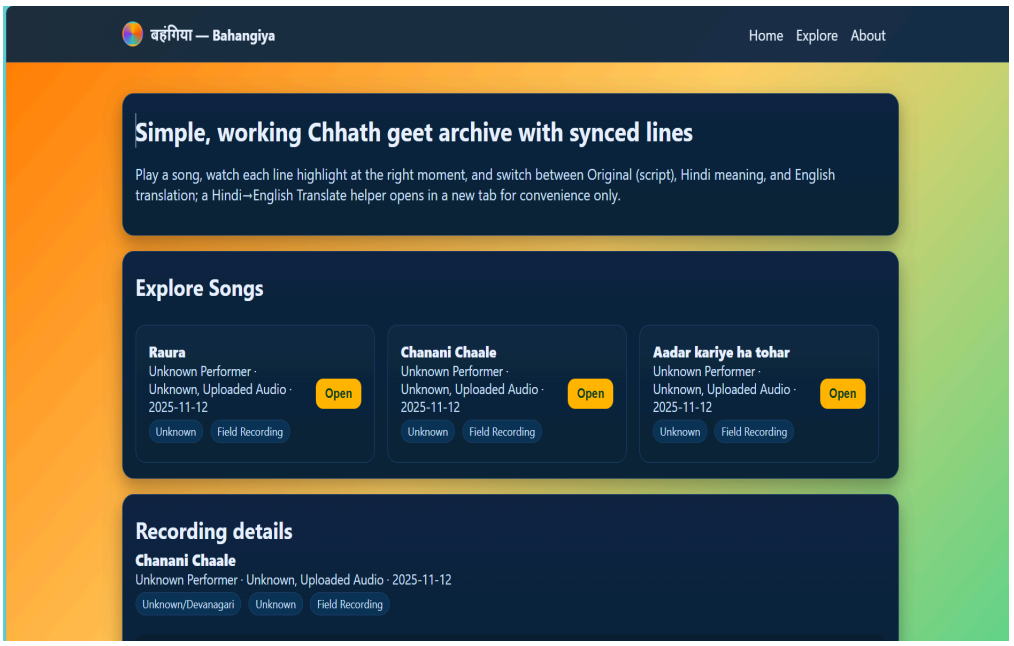

Fig. 2. shows an individual song entry with audio playback and contextual description.

The song archive deliberately includes multiple versions of similar songs to preserve variation across performers and locations. This approach aligns with folkloristic understandings of oral tradition as fluid and adaptive, and it resists the standardization that often accompanies digital preservation. Rather than presenting an authoritative or canonical version of Chhath music, the archive documents diversity as a core feature of the tradition.

The second element of the website is a historical map that situates songs and narratives within a spatial framework. Drawing on district gazetteers, archival sources, and interview references, the map highlights locations associated with ritual performance, migration, and memory. It functions not as a precise cartographic record but as an interpretive tool that connects oral tradition.

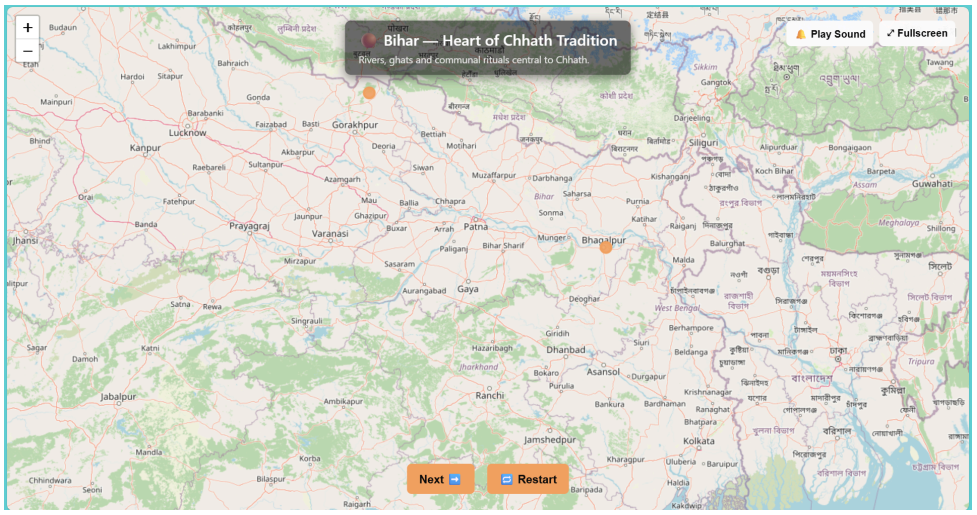

Fig. 3. shows the historical map interface used in the archive.

The map allows users to visualize how Chhath Puja practices are tied to rivers, towns, and regions in Bihar, particularly within Purvanchal. For migrant users and non local audiences, this spatial grounding provides essential context that complements the audio archive. The map also reflects narratives of movement and change, as many interview participants described shifts in ritual spaces due to migration, urbanization, and environmental transformation.

Together, the song archive and historical map create a coherent digital space that links sound, narrative, and place. By prioritizing ritual sequencing, contextual metadata, and spatial memory, the archive moves beyond simple documentation and functions as a reflective cultural resource. Its design demonstrates how focused, community oriented digital archives can support the safeguarding of living oral traditions while acknowledging their dynamic and evolving nature.

Discussion: Digital Archiving as Safeguarding Practice

This study understands digital archiving as a cultural safeguarding practice rather than a neutral technical process. The digital archive of Chhath Puja folk songs responds to the disruption of oral transmission caused by large-scale migration from Bihar, where traditional learning through family and community participation has become increasingly fragmented. As younger generations grow up away from ritual environments, opportunities for embodied song transmission decline, creating a rupture in intergenerational continuity.

Digital archiving addresses this rupture by creating an alternative space for access and remembrance. The archive enables migrant and younger community members to encounter songs, narratives, and ritual contexts beyond their immediate physical surroundings. It does not replace oral transmission but supplements it by supporting recall, recognition, and informal learning. Ethnomusicological scholarship suggests that mediated forms of access can sustain cultural memory when direct participation becomes limited, provided they remain connected to lived experience (Seeger 30). By foregrounding performer narratives and ritual sequencing, the archive seeks to preserve this connection.

At the same time, the archive functions as a digital memory space. Cultural memory, traditionally sustained through repeated ritual practice, is increasingly externalized through media and digital platforms (Assmann 21). The archive stores sound, voice, and spatial reference together, allowing memory to circulate in durable and accessible forms. However, memory in digital environments differs from ritual memory. It is often individual, selective, and screen mediated rather than collective and embodied. This shift underscores the tension between preservation and transformation that defines digital safeguarding.

Digital preservation inevitably transforms what it seeks to protect. When oral traditions are recorded and archived, they move from fluid, ephemeral performances to relatively stable digital artifacts. Folklore scholars caution that fixing oral traditions can limit variation and contextual richness (Finnegan 24). This project addresses this tension by documenting multiple versions of songs and by situating recordings within performer narratives and ritual

contexts. Transformation is therefore treated not as loss but as a condition of continuity, reflecting the adaptive nature of oral traditions.

The archive also reveals both gains and losses. Digital access increases visibility and enables dispersed communities to engage with traditions that may no longer be part of everyday ritual life. It creates space for recognizing individual performers whose contributions are often overlooked. At the same time, digital recordings cannot reproduce the full sensory, emotional, and collective dimensions of Chhath Puja, including environmental setting, bodily labor, and shared devotion. These limits highlight the need to understand digital archiving as supportive rather than substitutive.

By framing digital archiving as an ethically grounded safeguarding practice, this study contributes to debates in Digital Humanities and heritage studies. It demonstrates that small scale, community oriented digital archives can sustain cultural memory while acknowledging transformation, limitation, and change. Safeguarding, in this context, is not about fixing tradition in place but about creating conditions for continuity in an increasingly mobile and mediated world.

Challenges, Ethics, and Limitations

While digital archiving offers important possibilities for safeguarding oral traditions, it also involves significant challenges and ethical considerations. Recognizing these limitations is essential to responsible Digital Humanities research, particularly when working with living ritual practices such as Chhath Puja folk songs.

One key limitation is the loss of context that occurs when ritual performances are recorded and presented online. Chhath Puja songs are embedded in embodied practices, environmental settings, and collective participation. Audio and video recordings cannot fully capture the sensory and emotional dimensions of ritual performance, including shared labor, spatial atmosphere, and communal devotion. Although contextual descriptions and metadata help situate recordings, digital representation remains partial.

Access inequality presents another challenge. While digital platforms expand reach, they also depend on technological infrastructure that is unevenly distributed. Many performers and community members, particularly elders and rural participants, have limited access to reliable internet or digital devices. This creates unequal participation in both the creation and use of digital archives. Efforts to design a simple and mobile friendly interface reduce some barriers, but structural inequalities in digital access remain beyond the scope of the project.

Representation and authority pose further ethical risks. Digital archives require decisions about selection, description, and presentation, which can shape cultural narratives and privilege certain voices over others. There is a risk of presenting archived material as representative or authoritative, potentially fixing fluid traditions into stable forms. This project addresses this concern by including multiple versions of songs and foregrounding

performer narratives, yet it acknowledges that no archive can fully represent the diversity of lived practice.

Questions of ownership and consent are central to digital documentation. Oral traditions are often collectively held, and their translation into digital form can raise concerns about appropriation and misuse. Community based archiving principles guided the project, with informed consent and participant control over representation. However, ethical responsibility continues beyond the initial archive, as future circulation and interpretation remain unpredictable.

Sustainability is an ongoing limitation. Digital archives require long term maintenance, including hosting, software updates, and content management. Without institutional support, small scale digital projects risk becoming inaccessible over time. This uncertainty underscores the need to view digital archiving as an ongoing process rather than a completed task.

By acknowledging these challenges, the study avoids presenting digital archiving as a comprehensive solution. Instead, it frames the archive as a situated and partial intervention that supports continuity while respecting the dynamic and evolving nature of living traditions.

Conclusion

This study has examined how a community based digital archive can support the safeguarding of Chhath Puja folk songs as living oral and ritual traditions. By combining digital ethnography, oral history interviews, archival research, and participatory design, the project responds to the challenges created by migration and generational discontinuity. Rather than treating folk songs as static cultural objects, the archive documents them as practices shaped by performance, memory, and social relationships.

The analysis demonstrates that digital archiving can function as a meaningful safeguarding practice when it remains grounded in cultural context and community collaboration. The song archive and historical map together create a digital space that connects sound, narrative, and place, allowing dispersed and younger community members to engage with traditions that may no longer be transmitted through everyday ritual participation. At the same time, the study acknowledges that digital documentation cannot replace embodied ritual experience and should be understood as a supplementary form of cultural continuity.

By engaging critically with questions of preservation, transformation, and ethics, this paper contributes to debates in Digital Humanities, folkloristics, and ethnomusicology. It highlights the importance of treating digital archives not as neutral repositories but as cultural practices that shape memory, representation, and access. The project also demonstrates how small scale, focused digital interventions can address broader concerns about cultural vulnerability without imposing fixed or authoritative narratives.

Ultimately, safeguarding living oral traditions requires more than technological solutions. It demands sensitivity to community knowledge, attention to historical and spatial context, and ongoing ethical reflection. When guided by these principles, digital archiving can support the continuity of cultural memory while respecting the dynamic and evolving nature of tradition.

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